

Filing Tax Returns

It was time for the yearly ritual—where we tell the government that we have paid our taxes honestly. While Robert stayed put in his rather over-sized chair and checked his options to do so on their Web site, Garfield travelled, sneered, and scurried like rat from one office to another. Here is an account of what happened:

Garfield D'Souza (garfield_dsouza@thinkdigit.com)

Robert Sovereign-Smith (robert_smith@thinkdigit.com)



The returns form and challan, that's all you need

Last date of filing tax returns extended from 31st July to 31st Oct, 2004 for all assesses including salaried emp

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WHY FACE A DANGEROUS PENALTY OF RS. 10,000/- FOR NOT HAV

Use the phone instead of the browser...

1

I got the IT returns form (ITS 2E) from my HR department. Time now to fill it. Looked around for help. Found it in the form of a close relative—my dad. It took a day to get the form filled.

Time taken: 1 day and 10 minutes

I am not very comfortable with things that involve the words 'tax', 'bank', 'work', etc. I found FileReturn.com, and was immediately lost in all the jargon—the bad design of the Web site didn't help either. Thankfully they had a phone number!

Time taken 30 minutes (mostly spent trying to make sense of the site; we suggest you just call)

2

I realised I had to pay taxes this time. I needed a challan. This too came via the same route as the ITS 2E form.

Time taken: 1 day

I called them, told them I wanted everything done for me. Two days later a representative showed up at work. This thing works, then.

Time taken 3 days

3

The next day saw me at HDFC's Nerul branch. The staff prepared the challan in a little over 45 minutes.

Time taken : 30 minutes to travel, 45 minutes for the challan, Travel cost: Rs 20

The FileReturn.com representative asked me for my Form 16. Gave me a 'Saraal' form with two 'X's marking the spots I had to sign. I also signed a cheque for Rs 250, and was done.

Time taken 15 minutes

4

10:30 am Bandra-Kurla Complex: T-day! I walk into building C-13 of the Income Tax Department, Mumbai, and get my documents stamped. No long lines, no delays—kudos to the Government of India (or maybe I just got lucky today!)

Time taken : 45 minutes to travel, 2 minutes to submit, Travel cost: Rs 50

I was told I would get the stamped form back in two days time. Four days later I recieved it!

Time taken 4 days

Total Time Spent: 2 days, 2 hours and 12 minutes
Total cost: Rs 70



Total Time Spent: 7 days and 45 minutes
Total cost: Rs 250



AND
THE
WINNER
IS...

The old way is faster to get the stamped form in your hands. However, the actual time spent on filing taxes is practically nil with the tech way. If it's all about laziness, tech way wins hands down. The prob-

lem is Robert learnt absolutely nothing about income tax, while Garfield might actually be able to file his returns without his father's help next time. The old way most definitely teaches you a lot more.